ATC communication from stand to stand

A practical English phrasebook for a typical IFR flight. Examples use Speedbird 123 from Rome Fiumicino (LIRF) to London Heathrow (EGLL). Replace all names, routes, altitudes, runways, frequencies and instructions with the ones actually issued.

SIMULATION REFERENCE ONLY. Not for real-world navigation or operational use. Phraseology, clearances and procedures vary by country, airport and controller. Charts and current ATC instructions take priority.

Before the first call

Connect at a stand, clear of taxiways and runways. File an IFR flight plan, prepare charts and performance, listen to ATIS (record its letter), and check who is online. On VATSIM, an approach or centre controller may cover lower positions: check controller information before assuming there is no ATC.

Listen before transmitting. Use the full callsign on initial contact. Keep a pen ready. Say “new pilot” and ask for a slower transmission when useful. A radio check is optional; do not interrupt a busy frequency unnecessarily.

1 / Radio check and IFR clearance

PILOT: “Rome Delivery, Speedbird one two three, radio check.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, readability five.”
PILOT: “Readability five, Speedbird one two three.”

PILOT: “Rome Delivery, Speedbird one two three, stand two zero one, information Alpha, request IFR clearance to London Heathrow.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, cleared to London Heathrow via [departure], initial climb [altitude], squawk [code].”
PILOT: “Cleared to London Heathrow via [departure], initial climb [altitude], squawk [code], Speedbird one two three.”

Read back the actual clearance, including route or SID, initial altitude, transponder code and any other required items. “As filed” means the filed route only to the extent cleared by ATC; do not invent missing details. Request clarification if unsure.

2 / Pushback, start and taxi

PILOT: “Rome Ground, Speedbird one two three, stand two zero one, information Alpha, request pushback and start.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, pushback and start approved, facing west.”
PILOT: “Pushback and start approved, facing west, Speedbird one two three.”

PILOT: “Rome Ground, Speedbird one two three, ready to taxi.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, taxi to holding point runway two five via Alpha and Bravo, hold short of runway one six left.”
PILOT: “Taxi holding point runway two five via Alpha and Bravo, hold short of runway one six left, Speedbird one two three.”

Taxi only on the cleared route. A taxi clearance is not a runway crossing or takeoff clearance. Respect every hold-short instruction; obtain an explicit crossing clearance where required. If the route is unclear, stop and ask.

3 / Tower and departure

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, contact Tower on [frequency].”
PILOT: “Tower [frequency], Speedbird one two three.”
PILOT: “Rome Tower, Speedbird one two three, holding point runway two five, ready for departure.”

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, line up and wait runway two five.”
PILOT: “Line up and wait runway two five, Speedbird one two three.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, runway two five, cleared for takeoff.”
PILOT: “Runway two five, cleared for takeoff, Speedbird one two three.”

Line-up clearance does not permit takeoff. When instructed to contact departure, switch and report callsign, current altitude and assigned altitude, plus any locally required information.

PILOT: “Rome Departure, Speedbird one two three, passing two thousand feet, climbing five thousand feet.”

4 / Climb, cruise and handoffs

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, climb flight level one five zero.”
PILOT: “Climb flight level one five zero, Speedbird one two three.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, turn right heading two seven zero.”
PILOT: “Right heading two seven zero, Speedbird one two three.”

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, contact [unit] [frequency].”
PILOT: “[Unit] [frequency], Speedbird one two three.”
PILOT: “[Unit], Speedbird one two three, flight level three five zero.”

Read back assigned altitudes or flight levels, headings and turn direction, speeds, routes and frequencies. State current and assigned altitude if climbing or descending. Do not descend or turn merely because a chart shows a procedure: comply with the clearance received.

5 / Descent and approach

PILOT: “London Control, Speedbird one two three, request descent.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, descend flight level one one zero.”
PILOT: “Descend flight level one one zero, Speedbird one two three.”

PILOT: “London Approach, Speedbird one two three, passing flight level one three zero, descending flight level one one zero, information Bravo.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, turn left heading two seven zero, descend altitude four thousand feet, QNH one zero one three.”
PILOT: “Left heading two seven zero, descend altitude four thousand feet, QNH one zero one three, Speedbird one two three.”

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, cleared ILS approach runway two seven left.”
PILOT: “Cleared ILS approach runway two seven left, Speedbird one two three.”

Approach clearance is not landing clearance. Fly the assigned approach and restrictions. If unable to comply, tell ATC immediately.

6 / Landing, runway exit and parking

PILOT: “London Tower, Speedbird one two three, established ILS runway two seven left.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, runway two seven left, cleared to land.”
PILOT: “Runway two seven left, cleared to land, Speedbird one two three.”

ATC: “Speedbird one two three, vacate via [taxiway], contact Ground [frequency] when clear.”
PILOT: “Vacate via [taxiway], Ground [frequency] when clear, Speedbird one two three.”
PILOT: “London Ground, Speedbird one two three, runway two seven left vacated via [taxiway], request taxi to stand.”
ATC: “Speedbird one two three, taxi to stand [number] via [route].”
PILOT: “Stand [number] via [route], Speedbird one two three.”

After parking, follow local practice. If appropriate: “Speedbird one two three, on stand, thank you.” Disconnect only when you no longer need the network connection.

When you need help

“Say again, Speedbird one two three.”
“Confirm assigned altitude, Speedbird one two three.”
“Unable [instruction], request [alternative], Speedbird one two three.”
“Stand by, Speedbird one two three.”
“Speedbird one two three, going around.”

Acknowledge calls addressed to you. If you cannot safely comply, say “unable” rather than accepting. Go around when required; follow the published missed approach or ATC instructions as applicable, and advise ATC promptly.

Unstaffed airspace / advisory frequency

First check whether an overlying controller provides service. Without applicable ATC, use the appropriate VATSIM advisory frequency and text/voice procedures for that location; coordinate intentions and watch for traffic. Advisory calls are not ATC clearances. Check current VATSIM rules and local guidance.

Official references

VATSIM: Finding ATC / top-down coverage | VATSIM: Code of Conduct
VATSIM: First Flight Walkthrough | FAA: Radio communications